

Chapter 1 - What is History? (Compact Story Version)

The Big Argument

Picture two historians arguing. **Lord Acton** (1890s) says confidently, "We can write perfect, complete history if we collect ALL the facts!" He's like someone believing they can complete a jigsaw puzzle forever. Then **Sir George Clark** (1950s) says the opposite: "Everyone has their own view, so one history is as good as another - no objective truth exists!"

E.H. Carr says both are wrong! The truth is somewhere in between.

The Magic Spell Problem

A German historian **Ranke** (1830s) said the historian's job was "simply to show how it really was." This became like a magic spell that historians chanted for 100 years to avoid thinking deeply!

Then came the **Positivists** who said: "History is like fish on a slab. First collect all the facts, then draw conclusions. Facts are sacred, opinion is free."

Carr says: This will NOT do!

What Makes a Historical Fact?

Here's the shocking truth: **Not all facts about the past are historical facts!**

Example: Caesar crossing the Rubicon = historical fact. But millions of others crossed that same river = NOT historical facts. Why? **Because the historian decided Caesar's crossing matters!**

Pirandello's character said: "A fact is like a sack - it won't stand up till you've put something in it." Facts need the historian to give them meaning.

The Gingerbread Seller Story

In 1850 at Stalybridge Wakes, a gingerbread vendor was kicked to death by an angry mob. Is this a historical fact?

- **Before:** No - just mentioned in unknown memoirs, no historian cared

- **After Dr. Kitson Clark mentioned it in Oxford:** Maybe - it's "proposed for membership" in the club of historical facts
- **What decides its fate?** Whether other historians accept the interpretation it supports

The lesson: Facts become historical through historians accepting them, not by themselves!

The Illusion of Ancient History

Why ancient history seems easier: Few facts survived, so everything seems manageable.

The problem with ancient Greece: We only see it through **Athenian citizen eyes**. We know almost nothing about how Spartans, Corinthians, Persians, slaves, or non-citizens saw things!

Medieval history problem: Religious chroniclers recorded everything about religion, not much else. "**The dead hand of vanished generations**" already decided what we know.

Lytton Strachey said: "Ignorance is the first requisite of the historian - ignorance which simplifies and clarifies, which selects and omits."

Documents Don't Tell the Truth

Documents tell us what the author **thought** happened, or what he **wanted others to think**, or what he **wanted himself to think** - not what actually happened!

The Stresemann Papers Story

Gustav Stresemann (German Foreign Minister, died 1929) left **300 boxes** of documents. His secretary **Bernhard** selected from these and published 3 volumes (600 pages each).

What Bernhard did: He emphasized Stresemann's successful western policy (Locarno, League of Nations, etc.) because it seemed most important when Stresemann died.

In 1945: British and Americans captured the original 300 boxes and photographed everything. Now scholars could see exactly what Bernhard selected and what he left out!

The lesson: Even "primary sources" have been processed before historians see them!

The Italian Revolution: Croce

Benedetto Croce declared: "**All history is contemporary history**" - meaning we see the past through present eyes and present problems. The historian must **evaluate**, not just record. If you don't evaluate, how do you know what's worth recording?

Collingwood's Ideas

R.G. Collingwood said history is about **two things in mutual relations**:

1. The past itself
2. The historian's thought about it

Key ideas:

- "The past is not dead but living in the present"
- "All history is the history of thought"
- "History is re-enactment in the historian's mind of the thought whose history he is studying"

For readers: Just as historians re-enact historical figures' thoughts, **readers must re-enact the historian's thoughts!**

Practical advice: "Study the historian before you study the facts" - like the smart student who asks about Professor Jones's biases before reading his book!

The Fish in the Ocean

Carr's metaphor: Facts are like fish swimming in a vast ocean. What the historian catches depends on:

1. What part of ocean he fishes in

2. What tackle he uses These depend on **what kind of fish he wants to catch** - what questions he's asking!

Three Critical Points

1. Imaginative Understanding (Not Sympathy)

Historians need to understand minds of people they study, not necessarily agree.

Medieval history problem: 19th-century historians were too disgusted by medieval superstitions to understand medieval people.

Thirty Years War problem: Liberal historians thought killing for country = right, killing for religion = wrong. So they couldn't understand people who fought religious wars!

Cold War problem: English-speaking countries and Soviet Union couldn't understand each other - made the other side appear evil or senseless.

Key: History cannot be written unless historian achieves contact with minds of those he writes about.

2. We View Past Through Present Eyes

The historian is trapped in his own age. Words like democracy, empire, war have current meanings we can't escape.

Ancient historians try using original words (polis, plebs) to avoid this, **but it doesn't help!** Using a toga doesn't make you a better Roman historian!

The historian's function: Not to love or escape the past, but to **master and understand it as key to understanding the present.**

Examples of different viewpoints:

- **St. Augustine** - early Christian view
- **Gibbon** - 18th-century Englishman's view
- **Mommsen** - 19th-century German view

No point asking which was "right" - each was the only one possible for that person!

3. The Dangers

Danger 1: Sir George Clark's "infinity of meanings" - like saying a mountain has no shape because it looks different from different angles.

Danger 2: Pure pragmatism - **Nietzsche said:** "The falseness of an opinion is not an objection... the question is how far it is life-furthering." This means "who cares if it's true, is it useful?" - very dangerous!

The Historian's Real Duty

Two parts:

1. Accuracy: Like Housman said, "Accuracy is a duty, not a virtue" - it's necessary but not the main job. Basic facts (dates, places) are raw materials, not history itself.

2. Completeness: Include ALL relevant facts - even uncomfortable ones! If depicting Victorian Englishman as moral, you can't forget the Stalybridge Wakes mob killing!

But you **cannot eliminate interpretation** - it's the life-blood of history.

Two Wrong Paths

Path 1: Scissors-and-paste history - just cutting and pasting facts with no meaning.

Path 2: Propaganda or historical fiction - using facts to embroider stories, not real history.

CARR'S FINAL ANSWER

The historian and facts need each other:

- **Historian without facts** = rootless and futile (tree with no roots)
- **Facts without historian** = dead and meaningless (corpse)

"History is a continuous process of interaction between the historian and his facts, an unending dialogue between the present and the past."

It's not past speaking alone. Not historian making things up alone. It's **both in constant conversation** - present asks questions, past provides

materials, historian interprets, new questions arise, dialogue continues forever.

Each generation asks new questions from new concerns and sees from new angles. History is **dynamic, not static** - a conversation, not a monologue - a **process, not a finished product**.

Quick Exam Points:

- History is NOT just collecting facts
- Facts don't speak for themselves - historians give them voice
- Historical facts created through interpretation
- Must study the historian to understand the history
- Need imaginative understanding of subjects
- We inevitably view past through present eyes
- History is INTERACTION between facts and historian
- History is DIALOGUE between present and past

Key Examples: Gingerbread vendor, Stresemann papers, fish in ocean, Stalybridge Wakes

Chapter 2 - Society and the Individual (Compact Story Version)

The Big Idea: You Can't Separate Individual and Society

Imagine trying to separate a fish from water - that's how impossible it is to separate the individual from society. **Society and the individual are inseparable** - they're necessary and complementary to each other, not opposites.

John Donne's famous words: "No man is an island, entire of itself; every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main."

From the moment we're born, the world gets to work on us and transforms us from merely biological creatures into social beings. Every human being at every stage of history is born into a society, and from earliest years is molded by that society.

Example: The language you speak is not an individual inheritance - it's a **social acquisition** from the group you grow up in. Your language and environment determine the character of your thought. Your earliest ideas come from others, not from inside you.

Carr's striking statement: "Suicide is the only perfectly free act open to individual man; every other act involves in one way or another his membership of society."

Primitive vs Civilized Man - The Misconception

Anthropologists commonly say primitive man is less individual and more completely molded by his society than civilized man. This contains **an element of truth** but is misleading.

The truth: Simpler societies are more uniform - they call for and provide opportunities for far smaller diversity of individual skills and occupations than complex societies. But this doesn't mean primitive people are "less individual."

Key point: The development of society and the development of the individual **go hand in hand and condition each other**. Civilized man, like primitive man, is molded by society just as effectively as society is molded by him.

The chicken-and-egg problem: You can no more have the egg without the hen than you can have the hen without the egg. Same with individual and society!

The Rise of Individualism - A Historical Story

The Renaissance Beginning

The cult of the individual began with the **Renaissance**. Before this, man was "conscious of himself only as a member of a race, people, party, family, or corporation." Then something changed - man "became a spiritual individual and recognized himself as such."

Capitalism, Protestantism, and Industrial Revolution

Later, individualism got connected with:

- The rise of capitalism
- Rise of Protestantism
- Beginnings of the industrial revolution
- Doctrines of laissez-faire (leave alone, free market)

The **French Revolution** proclaimed "the rights of man and the citizen" - these were the rights of the **individual**.

19th Century: The Peak of Individualism

Individualism became the basis of the great 19th-century philosophy of **utilitarianism**.

Morley's essay "On Compromise" (a classic Victorian liberal document) called individualism and utilitarianism "the religion of human happiness and well-being."

"Rugged individualism" was seen as the keynote of human progress. Why? Because in early capitalism, production and distribution units were largely in the hands of single individuals. So the ideology of this new social order strongly emphasized **individual initiative**.

But Here's the Catch

These were not really struggles between individuals versus society. They were **struggles between groups of individuals in society** - each group trying to promote social policies favorable to it and frustrate policies harmful to it!

The Historian as Individual and Social Being

Now Carr brings it back to historians. The historian is an individual human being. But like other individuals, he is also a **social phenomenon** - both the product and the conscious or unconscious spokesman of the society to which he belongs. It's in this capacity that he approaches the facts of the historical past.

The Moving Procession Metaphor

We sometimes speak of history as a "moving procession." We might say, for example, that we are nearer today to the Middle Ages than our great-grandfathers were a century ago, or that the age of Caesar is nearer to us than the age of Dante.

Why? Because our concerns and problems might resemble medieval or Roman concerns more than those of other periods.

Key principle: The historian is part of history. The point in the procession at which he finds himself determines his angle of vision over the past.

Three Brilliant Historical Examples

1. Grote and Athenian Democracy (1840s)

George Grote was an enlightened radical banker writing in the 1840s. He embodied the aspirations of the rising, politically progressive British middle class in an idealized picture of Athenian democracy.

What he did:

- Made Pericles look like a Benthamite reformer (contemporary British reformer type)
- Made Athens acquire its empire "in a fit of absence of mind" (like the British Empire!)

The revealing omission: Grote neglected the problem of slavery in Athens. Why? This reflected the failure of the group he belonged to - the British middle class - to face the problem of the new English factory working class! They ignored Greek slaves just as they were ignoring British workers!

2. Mommsen and the Strong Man (1850s)

Theodor Mommsen was a German liberal, disillusioned by the muddles and humiliations of the German revolution of 1848-49.

Context: Writing in the 1850s - the decade that saw the birth of the name and concept of **Realpolitik** (realistic politics, power politics).

Mommsen's mindset: He was imbued with the sense of need for a strong man to clear up the mess left by the failure of the German people to realize its political aspirations.

How this affected his history:

- His well-known **idealization of Caesar** is the product of this yearning for a strong man to save Germany from ruin
- The lawyer-politician **Cicero** appears as an ineffective chatterbox and slippery procrastinator - he had walked straight out of the debates of the Paulskirche in Frankfurt in 1848!

Mommsen wasn't writing about ancient Rome - he was writing about his own Germany through Roman history!

Two Crucial Lessons

First: You cannot fully understand or appreciate the work of the historian unless you have first grasped the standpoint from which he himself approached it.

Second: That standpoint is itself rooted in a social and historical background.

Marx once said: "The educator himself has to be educated." In modern jargon, **the brain of the brain-washer has itself been washed!**

The historian, before he begins to write history, is the product of history.

The Tragic Story of Meinecke - Four Periods, Four Histories

Friedrich Meinecke was a German historian whose work reflected four different periods of German history. This is a perfect example of how historians reflect their times:

Period 1: Before WWI

The young, confident Meinecke of pre-1914 Germany.

Period 2: 1925 - Weimar Republic

His book: "Die Idee der Staatsräson" (The Idea of Reason of State) **His mindset:** Speaks with the divided and bewildered mind of the Weimar Republic. Politics has become an arena of unresolved conflict between *raison d'état* (reasons of state) and morality external to politics.

Period 3: 1936 - Nazi Period

His book: "Die Entstehung des Historismus" **What happened:** He had been swept from his academic honors by the Nazi flood. **His response:** A cry of despair, rejecting a historicism that appears to say "Whatever is, is right." He's tossing uneasily between the historical relative and a super-rational absolute.

Period 4: 1946 - After WWII Defeat

His book: "Die Deutsche Katastrophe" (The German Catastrophe) **Context:** His old age, after seeing his country succumb to a military defeat more crushing than 1918. **His response:** Relapses helplessly into belief in a history at the mercy of blind, inexorable chance.

What interests the historian: Not Meinecke's personal development, but the way he reflects back three or even four successive, sharply contrasted periods of present time into the historical past!

British Historians and Progress

In the 19th century, British historians with scarcely an exception regarded history as a demonstration of the principle of **progress**. Why? They expressed the ideology of a society in a condition of remarkably rapid progress!

History was full of meaning for British historians as long as it seemed to be going their way. Now that it has taken a wrong turning, belief in the meaning of history has become a heresy!

After WWI: Toynbee made a desperate attempt to replace a linear view of history by a **cyclical theory** - the characteristic ideology of a society in decline.

The change since 1914: This reflects a fundamental change in the character and outlook of our society.

Universal truth: The thought of historians, as of other human beings, is molded by the environment of the time and place.

Carr's Updated Advice

In Lecture 1, Carr said: "Before you study the history, study the historian."

Now he adds: "Before you study the historian, study his historical and social environment."

The historian, being an individual, is also a product of history and of society; and it is in this twofold light that the student of history must learn to regard him.

The "Great Man" Theory - A Childish View?

The Ancient Greek Tradition

Ancient Greeks liked to label achievements with names of eponymous heroes supposedly responsible for them:

- Attribute their epics to a bard called Homer
- Their laws and institutions to a Lycurgus or a Solon

In Britain: We all learned this theory "at our mother's knee." Today we should recognize there is something **childish, or at any rate childlike**, about it.

When it made sense: It had plausibility when society was simpler and public affairs appeared to be run by a handful of known individuals.

Why it doesn't fit now: It clearly does not fit the more complex society of our times. The birth of the new science of **sociology** in the 19th century was a response to this growing complexity.

The Old Tradition Dies Hard

At the beginning of the 20th century, "**History is the biography of great men**" was still a reputable dictum (Carlyle's unfortunate assertion).

Ten years ago (from Carr's 1960s lectures): A distinguished American historian accused his colleagues of the "mass murder of historical characters" by treating them as "puppets of social and economic forces."

Modern Examples of This Mistake

Sir Isaiah Berlin is terribly worried that historians may fail to denounce Genghis Khan and Hitler as bad men.

Common tendency: It's easier and more comfortable to attribute:

- The Bolshevik Revolution to the stupidity of Nicholas II or to German gold (rather than study its profound social causes)
- The two world wars to the individual wickedness of Wilhelm II and Hitler (rather than some deep-seated breakdown in the system of international relations)

Miss Wedgwood's Two Propositions

Carr analyzes a statement by Miss Wedgwood that combines two propositions:

Proposition 1: The behavior of men as individuals is distinct from their behavior as members of groups or classes. The historian may legitimately choose to dwell on one rather than the other.

Proposition 2: The study of behavior of men as individuals consists of studying the conscious motives of their actions.

Carr's Response to Proposition 1

The problem: It's not that the view of man as an individual is more or less misleading than the view of him as a member of a group. **The attempt to draw a distinction between the two is what's misleading!**

Why? The individual is by definition a member of a society - or probably of more than one society (group, class, tribe, nation, whatever you call it).

"Psychologism": Some people distinguish between psychology (science of the individual) and sociology (science of society). The name "psychologism" has been given to the view that all social problems are ultimately reducible to analysis of individual human behavior.

Carr's position: Reserve the word "history" for the process of inquiry into the past of man **in society**.

Carr's Response to Proposition 2

The second point - that history is concerned with why individuals "in their own estimation, acted as they did" - seems extremely odd!

Carr suspects: Miss Wedgwood, like other sensible people, does not practice what she preaches. If she does, she must write some very queer history!

Example - King John:

- **Simple view:** King John's badness consisted in his greed, stupidity, or ambition to play the tyrant - these are individual qualities comprehensible even at nursery history level
- **Complex view:** Once you say King John was the unconscious tool of vested interests opposed to the rise of feudal barons, you introduce a more sophisticated view AND suggest that historical events are determined not by conscious actions of individuals, but by extraneous, all-powerful forces guiding their unconscious will

Carlyle's Contradiction

Carlyle was responsible for "history is the biography of great men." But listen to him at his most eloquent in his greatest historical work - he actually talks about masses, not just great men!

Lenin said: "Politics begin where the masses are; not where there are thousands, but where there are millions, that is where serious politics begin."

Crucial point: People do not cease to be people, or individuals individuals, because we do not know their names!

The Power of Nameless Millions

These nameless millions were **individuals acting more or less unconsciously, together, and constituting a social force.**

Key principle: The historian will not ordinarily need to take notice of:

- A single discontented peasant or discontented village

But: Millions of discontented peasants in thousands of villages are a factor which no historian will ignore!

Another example: The reasons which deter Jones from getting married do not interest the historian UNLESS the same reasons also deter thousands of other individuals of Jones's generation and bring about a substantial fall in the marriage rate. In that event, they may well be historically significant!

Tolstoy's Insight

Tolstoy in War and Peace: "Man lives consciously for himself, but serves as an unconscious instrument for the achievement of historical, universally human goals."

Another Tolstoy quote: "There is something in the nature of historical events which twists the course of history in a direction that no man ever intended."

The World Wars Example

Since 1914, after a hundred years of only minor local wars, we've had two major world wars.

Would this be plausible? To maintain that more individuals wanted war, or fewer wanted peace, in the first half of the 20th century than in the last three quarters of the 19th? No!

The Great Depression Example

It's difficult to believe that any individual willed or desired the great economic depression of the 1930s. Yet it was indubitably brought about by the actions of individuals, each consciously pursuing some totally different aim!

Conclusion: It defies all the evidence to suggest that history can be written on the basis of "explanations in terms of human intentions."

What Are Historical Facts Really About?

The facts of history are indeed facts about individuals, but:

- NOT about actions of individuals performed in isolation
- NOT about the motives, real or imaginary, from which individuals suppose themselves to have acted

They are facts about:

1. The relations of individuals to one another in society
2. The social forces which produce from the actions of individuals results often at variance with, and sometimes opposite to, the results which they themselves intended

The Role of the Great Man

Someone once said (though not seriously) that the history of modern Europe can be written in terms of three titans: Napoleon, Bismarck, and Lenin.

The question: What is the role of the great man in history?

Answer: The great man is an individual, and being an outstanding individual, is also a social phenomenon of outstanding importance.

The Bismarck example: Had Bismarck been born in the 18th century - an absurd hypothesis, since he would not then have been Bismarck - he would not have united Germany and might not have been a great man at all!

Wrong view: Great men as "jack-in-the-boxes who emerge miraculously from the unknown to interrupt the real continuity of history."

Right view: The great man is always representative either of existing forces OR of forces which he helps to create by way of challenge to existing authority.

Two types of great men:

1. Those like Lenin (who help create new forces by challenging existing authority)
2. Those like Napoleon or Bismarck (who rode to greatness on the back of already existing forces)

The Final Understanding

The reciprocal process of interaction between the historian and his facts - what Carr called the dialogue between present and past - is a dialogue **not between abstract and isolated individuals**, but between **the society of today and the society of yesterday**.

Burckhardt's words: History is "the record of what one age finds worthy of note in another."

Two-way understanding:

- The past is intelligible to us only in the light of the present
- We can fully understand the present only in the light of the past

Chapter 3 - History, Science and Morality (Compact Story Version)

The Big Question: Is History a Science?

At the end of the 18th century, when science had contributed triumphantly to man's knowledge of the world and his physical attributes, people began asking: **Can science also further man's knowledge of society?**

Evolution in science confirmed and complemented progress in history. **Bury**, in his inaugural lecture of January 1903, described history as "**a science, no more and no less.**"

Modern astronomy has become a science of how the universe came to be what it is. Modern physicists constantly tell us they investigate not facts, but **events**. So history isn't alone in dealing with change and events!

The Problem with "Laws" in History

The Old Scientific View

Throughout 18th and 19th centuries, scientists assumed that **laws of nature** had been discovered and definitely established:

- Newton's laws of motion
- Law of gravitation
- Boyle's law
- Law of evolution

The scientist's business was to discover more such laws by induction from observed facts.

Buckle in his History of Civilization expressed conviction that human affairs were "permeated by one glorious principle of universal and undeviating regularity."

The New Understanding

Today, it's recognized that scientists make discoveries and acquire fresh knowledge **not by establishing precise laws**, but by **enunciating hypotheses** which open the way to fresh inquiry.

The key word: "Reciprocal" - not circular! The result is not to return to the same place, but to **move forward to fresh discoveries** through interaction between principles and facts, between theory and practice.

All thinking requires acceptance of certain presuppositions based on observation, which make scientific thinking possible but are **subject to revision** in the light of that thinking.

Rutherford's Method

Rutherford (famous scientist) was described by a distinguished pupil: "He had a driving urge to know how nuclear phenomena worked, in the sense in which one could speak of knowing what went on in the kitchen. I do not believe he searched for an explanation in the classical manner of a theory using certain basic laws; **as long as he knew what was happening he was content.**"

This description equally fits the historian, who has abandoned the search for basic laws and is content to inquire **how things work**.

Marx's Statement Example

Take Marx's statement: "The hand-mill gives us a society with a feudal lord; the steam-mill gives us a society with an industrial capitalist."

This isn't a scientific law but a **generalization showing relationship** between technology and social structure.

Hypotheses, Not Facts

When we lose comfortable formulas that have been our guides amid complexities of existence, we feel like drowning in the ocean of facts until we find a new foothold or learn to swim.

Periodization is a Hypothesis

The division of history into periods is **not a fact**, but a **necessary hypothesis or tool of thought**, valid insofar as it is illuminating, and dependent on interpretation.

Examples:

- The division into "Ancient, Medieval, Modern"

- "The Renaissance"
- "The Industrial Revolution"

Geographical Divisions Are Hypotheses

The division of history into geographical sectors is equally not a fact, but a hypothesis. To speak of "European history" may be valid and fruitful in some contexts, misleading in others.

Example: Most historians assume Russia is part of Europe; some passionately deny it!

One should proceed by feeling one's way; try out probable and partial hypotheses, and be satisfied with provisional approximations so as always to leave the door open to progressive correction.

This is far from the 19th century when scientists and historians like Acton looked forward to establishing, through accumulation of well-attested facts, a comprehensive body of knowledge which would settle all disputed issues once for all.

History vs Science: The Key Objections

Carr lists five main objections to calling history a science:

1. History deals with the unique, science with the general
2. History teaches no lessons
3. History cannot predict
4. History is subjective (man observing himself)
5. History involves issues of religion and morality

Let's examine each:

Objection 1: The Unique vs The General

The Traditional View

This view starts with **Aristotle**, who declared that poetry was "more philosophical" and "more serious" than history, since poetry was concerned with general truth and history with particular.

Hobbes's famous dictum: "Nothing in the world is universal but names, for the things named are every one of them individual and singular."

This is true of physical sciences too: no two geological formations, no two animals of the same species, no two atoms are identical. Similarly, **no two historical events are identical.**

But Here's the Catch

When **Gibbon** wrote of both the establishment of Christianity by Constantine and the rise of Islam as "revolutions," he was generalizing two unique events. Modern historians do the same when they write of the English, French, Russian, and Chinese revolutions.

The truth: The historian is not really interested in the unique, but in **what is general in the unique.**

Example: Causes of WWI

In the 1920s: Discussions assumed it was due to mismanagement of diplomats working in secret, or the division of the world into territorial sovereign states.

In the 1930s: Discussions assumed it was due to rivalries between imperialist powers driven by stresses of capitalism in decline.

These discussions all involved **generalization about causes of war.**

Carr's Personal Example

When Carr reads Carlyle's French Revolution, he finds himself again and again generalizing Carlyle's comments by applying them to the Russian revolution.

Conclusion: It is nonsense to say that generalization is foreign to history; **history thrives on generalizations.**

As Mr. Elton puts it: "What distinguishes the historian from the collector of historical facts is generalization."

Marx on Generalization

Marx (often accused of constructing rigid patterns) actually said: "Events strikingly similar, but occurring in a different historical milieu, lead to completely dissimilar results. By studying each of these evolutions separately and then comparing them, it is easy to find the key to understanding."

Key principle: History is concerned with the **relation between the unique and the general**. You can no more separate them than you can separate fact and interpretation.

Sociology and History

Sociology faces two opposite dangers:

Danger 1: Becoming ultra-theoretical - losing itself in abstract, meaningless generalizations about "Society" with a big S (as misleading as "History" with a big H).

Danger 2: Becoming ultra-empirical - splitting into discrete technical problems of social readjustment.

Solution: Sociology must, like history, concern itself with the relation between the unique and the general. It must also become **dynamic** - a study not of society at rest (no such society exists), but of **social change and development**.

Carr's advice: The more sociological history becomes, and the more historical sociology becomes, the better for both. **Let the frontier between them be kept wide open for two-way traffic.**

Objection 2: History Teaches No Lessons

The Real Point About Generalization

Through generalization, we attempt to **learn from history**, to apply the lesson drawn from one set of events to another set of events. When we generalize, we're consciously or unconsciously trying to do this.

The Paris Peace Conference 1919 - Carr's Personal Example

Everyone in the delegation believed they could learn from the lessons of the Vienna Congress (last great European peace congress a hundred years earlier).

Two lessons they drew:

1. It was dangerous, when re-drawing Europe's map, to neglect the principle of self-determination
2. It was dangerous to throw secret documents in your waste-paper basket - contents would certainly be bought by another delegation's secret service!

Rome and Greece Example

Everyone knows about the impact of ancient Greece upon Rome. But has any historian attempted precise analysis of the lessons which Romans learned, or believed themselves to have learned, from the history of Greece?

Russian Revolution Example

The makers of the Russian revolution were profoundly impressed - one might almost say **obsessed** - by the lessons of:

- The French revolution
- The revolutions of 1848
- The Paris commune of 1871

Carr's principle: To learn about the present in the light of the past means also to learn about the past in the light of the present.

Objection 3: History Cannot Predict

The Misunderstanding About Scientific Laws

Scientists are no longer as eager as they used to be to talk about "laws of nature." The so-called laws of science which affect our ordinary life are in fact **statements of tendency** - statements of what will happen other things being equal or in laboratory conditions.

They don't claim to predict what will happen in concrete cases:

- The law of gravity doesn't prove that particular apple will fall - somebody may catch it in a basket
- The law of optics that light travels in a straight line doesn't prove a particular ray won't be refracted by some intervening object

Modern physical theories deal only with the **probabilities** of events taking place.

What Historians Can and Cannot Predict

The historian is bound to generalize; in doing so, he provides **general guides for future action** which, though not specific predictions, are both valid and useful.

But he cannot predict specific events, because the specific is unique and the element of accident enters into it.

Example - Medical analogy: You cannot predict that Mary will catch measles. But you can predict that in present conditions a certain number of people will catch measles, and that if Mary is exposed to infection the chances are so-and-so that she will catch it.

Example - Revolution in Ruritania: People don't expect the historian to predict that revolution will break out in Ruritania next month. The kind of conclusion they seek is that **conditions in Ruritania are such that a revolution is likely** to occur in the near future if somebody touches it off, or unless somebody on the government side does something to stop it.

This doesn't mean that inferences drawn from history about the future are worthless. They possess a **conditional validity** which serves both as a guide to action and a key to our understanding of how things happen.

Objection 4: History is Subjective (The Most Cogent Argument)

The Problem

In the social sciences, subject and object belong to the same category and interact reciprocally on each other.

Human beings are not only the most complex and variable of natural entities, but they have to be studied **by other human beings**, not by independent observers of another species.

The sociologist, economist, or historian needs to penetrate into forms of human behavior in which **the will is active**, to ascertain why human beings who are the object of study willed to act as they did.

This sets up a relation, peculiar to history and social sciences, between the observer and what is observed. **The point of view of the historian enters irrevocably into every observation he makes; history is shot through and through with relativity.**

The Self-Fulfilling/Self-Frustrating Prophecy

Human beings whose behavior is made the object of analysis and prediction may be warned in advance by the prediction of consequences unwelcome to them, and be induced to modify their action, so that the prediction, however correctly based, proves **self-frustrating**.

One reason why **history rarely repeats itself** among historically conscious people is that the dramatis personae are aware at the second performance of the denouement of the first, and their action is affected by that knowledge.

The Napoleon Example

The Bolsheviks knew that the French revolution had ended in a Napoleon, and feared their revolution might end the same way.

Therefore: They mistrusted Trotsky (who among their leaders looked most like a Napoleon) and trusted Stalin (who looked least like a Napoleon).

But: This process may work in converse direction - sometimes the very attempt to avoid one outcome produces exactly that outcome!

Comparisons with Modern Physics

In modern physics:

- Distances in space and lapses of time have measures depending on the motion of the "observer"
- All measurements are subject to inherent variations due to impossibility of establishing a constant relation between observer and object under observation

While these descriptions apply with minimal change to relations between historian and his observations, Carr is **not satisfied** that the essence of these relations is in any real sense comparable with the nature of relations between physicist and his universe.

Objection 5: Religion and Morality

The Religion Question

To be a serious astronomer is compatible with belief in a God who created and ordered the universe. But it's **not compatible** with belief in a God who intervenes at will to change the course of a planet, postpone an eclipse, or alter the rules of the cosmic game.

Same with history: A serious historian may believe in a God who has ordered and given meaning to the course of history as a whole, though he cannot believe in the Old Testament kind of God who intervenes to slaughter the Amalekites or cheats on the calendar by extending hours of daylight for Joshua's army.

Nor can he invoke God as an explanation of particular historical events.

The Morality Question - Private Life

It's scarcely necessary today to argue that the historian is not required to pass moral judgments on the **private life** of characters in his story.

The standpoints of the historian and the moralist are not identical. Henry VIII may have been a bad husband and a good king. But the historian is interested in him in the former capacity only insofar as it affected historical events.

This goes for virtues as well as vices. Pasteur and Einstein were men of exemplary, even saintly, private lives. But suppose they had been

unfaithful husbands, cruel fathers, and unscrupulous colleagues - would it matter for their scientific contributions? No!

The Acton View (Wrong)

Acton's view was based on an almost mystical belief in the objectivity and supremacy of historical facts, which apparently requires and entitles the historian, in the name of History as a sort of super-historical power, to pass moral judgments on individuals participating in historical events.

Professor Toynbee described Mussolini's invasion of Abyssinia in 1935 as a "deliberate personal sin."

Sir Isaiah Berlin insists with great vehemence that it's the duty of the historian "to judge Charlemagne or Napoleon or Genghis Khan or Hitler or Stalin for their massacres."

Croce's Response (Right)

Our tribunals (whether juridical or moral) are present-day tribunals designed for living, active, and dangerous men, while those other men have already appeared before the tribunal of their day, and **cannot be condemned or absolved twice**.

They cannot be held responsible before any tribunal, just because they are men of the past who belong to the peace of the past and can only be subjects of history, and can suffer no other judgment than that which penetrates and understands the spirit of their work.

The Real Moral Judgments

These are the important judgments of the historian. Those who insist so fervently on the moral condemnation of individuals sometimes unconsciously provide an **alibi for whole groups and societies**.

Example - Lefèbvre: The French historian, seeking to exonerate the French revolution from responsibility for disasters and bloodshed of Napoleonic wars, attributed them to "the dictatorship of a general whose temperament could not easily acquiesce in peace and moderation."

Judge Institutions, Not Individuals

Max Weber: Refers to "the masterless slavery in which capitalism enmeshes the worker or the debtor," and rightly argues that the historian should **pass moral judgment on the institution, but not on the individuals who created it.**

The historian will condemn a slave-owning society but will not pass judgment on the individual slave-owner.

The Cost of Progress - The Most Complicated Question

This is exceedingly complicated because we have no measure which enables us to balance the greater good of some against the sacrifices of others - yet some such balance must be struck.

In history, the question is sometimes discussed under the rubric "**the cost of progress**" or "**the price of revolution.**" This is misleading. The thesis that the good of some justifies the sufferings of others is implicit in **all government**, and is just as much a conservative as a radical doctrine.

The Industrial Revolution Example

The industrialization of Great Britain between about 1780 and 1870:

What virtually every historian does:

- Treats the industrial revolution as a great and progressive achievement (probably without discussion)
- Also describes the driving of peasantry off the land
- Herding of workers in unhealthy factories and unsanitary dwellings
- Exploitation of child labor
- Will probably say that abuses occurred in the working of the system
- Some employers were more ruthless than others
- Will dwell with some unctiousness on the gradual growth of a humanitarian conscience once the system became established

Colonization Example

Historians condone the 19th-century colonization of Asia and Africa by western nations on the ground not only of its immediate effects on the world economy, but of its long-term consequences for the backward peoples.

After all, it is said, modern India is the child of British rule; and modern China is the product of 19th-century western imperialism, crossed with the influence of the Russian revolution.

The problem: Those who pay the cost are rarely those who reap the benefits.

Marx's Brutal Honesty

Marx on history (quoted by Carr): "History is about the most cruel of all goddesses, and she leads her triumphal car over heaps of corpses, not only in war, but also in 'peaceful' economic development. And we men and women are unfortunately so stupid that we never pluck up courage for real progress unless urged to it by sufferings that seem almost out of proportion."

The Cheque Metaphor

The moral precepts which we apply in history or in everyday life are **like cheques on a bank**: they have a printed and a written part.

The printed part: Abstract words like liberty, equality, justice, democracy. These are essential categories.

But the cheque is valueless until we fill in the other part, which states **how much liberty we propose to allocate to whom, whom we recognize as our equals, and up to what amount.**

History is Movement

History is movement; and movement implies comparison. That's why historians tend to express their moral judgments in words of a **comparative nature** like "progressive" and "reactionary" rather than in uncompromising absolutes like "good" and "bad."

These are attempts to define different societies or historical phenomena not in relation to some absolute standard, but **in their relation to one another**.

The serious historian is the one who recognizes the historically-conditioned character of all values, not the one who claims for his own values an objectivity beyond history.

The beliefs which we hold and the standards of judgment which we set up are part of history, and are as much subject to historical investigation as any other aspect of human behavior.

Final Answer: Is History a Science?

The word "science" already covers so many different branches of knowledge, employing so many different methods and techniques, that **the onus seems to rest on those who seek to exclude history** rather than on those who seek to include it.

Significant fact: Arguments for exclusion come not from scientists anxious to exclude historians from their select company, but from **historians and philosophers anxious to vindicate the status of history as a branch of humane letters**.

The dispute reflects the prejudice of the old division between humanities and science, in which the humanities were supposed to represent the broad culture of the ruling class, and science the skills of the technicians who served it.

But: Historian and physical scientist are united in:

- The fundamental purpose of seeking to explain
- The fundamental procedure of question and answer

The historian, like any other scientist, is an animal who incessantly asks the question "Why?"